



Self-Care Menu

A GUIDE FOR YOUNG PEOPLE

In today's busy world, taking time for yourself is more important than ever, especially for young people navigating school, friendships, and growing up. This menu is designed to help you discover and practice self-care in ways that feel good and energizing for *you*.

Think of self-care not as a luxury, but as a necessity. It's about actively taking steps to protect your well-being and boost your happiness. It's not selfish; it's essential for being your best self. What works for one person might not work for another, so feel free to mix and match from our menu, or even create your own unique self-care practices!

Remember, self-care is a journey, not a destination. Be patient with yourself and celebrate every small step you take towards prioritizing your well-being.

Mindful Moments (Quick Refreshers)

These are quick and easy ways to reset when you're feeling overwhelmed or just need a little pick-me-up. They can be done almost anywhere, anytime!

- **Deep Breathing:** Take 5 slow, deep breaths. Inhale through your nose, feeling your belly rise, and exhale slowly through your mouth. Focus only on your breath.
- **Mindful Listening:** Put on your favorite song (or just listen to the sounds around you) for 5 minutes. Really focus on the different sounds you hear.
- **Stretch It Out:** Stand up and do a few simple stretches. Reach for the sky, touch your toes, or do some gentle neck rolls.
- **Hydration Station:** Drink a glass of water. Sometimes, feeling tired or unfocused is just a sign of dehydration.
- **Quick Gratitude:** Think of three things you are grateful for right now. They can be big or small!

Creative & Expressive Outlets

Engaging your creativity can be a powerful way to process emotions and have fun. You don't need to be an artist to enjoy these!

- **Doodle or Draw:** Grab a pen and paper and just start doodling. Let your imagination run wild.
- **Journaling:** Write down your thoughts, feelings, or even a story. No one else has to read it!
- **Creative Writing:** Try writing a short poem, a scene for a movie, or song lyrics.

- **Music Maker:** Sing along to your favorite songs, or try to create a simple melody on an instrument if you have one.
- **Build Something:** Use LEGOs, building blocks, or even just rearrange items around you to create something new.

Connection & Comfort

Connecting with others or finding comfort in familiar things can be incredibly soothing.

- **Talk it Out:** Chat with a trusted friend, family member, or mentor about how you're feeling.
- **Cuddle Up:** Spend time with a pet or wrap yourself in a cozy blanket.
- **Watch Something Uplifting:** Enjoy a funny movie, a comforting TV show, or inspiring videos.
- **Connect with Nature:** Spend time outdoors, even if it's just sitting in a park or looking out your window.
- **Comfort Food (Mindfully):** Enjoy a favorite snack or meal, savoring each bite.

Movement & Energy

Getting your body moving can release tension and boost your mood.

- **Dance Break:** Put on your favorite upbeat music and dance around your room.
- **Go for a Walk:** A short walk outside can do wonders for your perspective.
- **Try a Quick Workout:** Look up a short, fun workout video online (yoga, cardio, etc.).
- **Play a Sport:** If you enjoy it, engage in a sport you like, even just for a little while.
- **Active Chores:** Sometimes, even tidying your room or doing a quick chore can feel productive and energizing.

Activity: Create Your Self-Care Jar!

Now it's time to make your own personalized self-care toolkit! This activity will help you create a tangible reminder of all the wonderful ways you can take care of yourself.

What you'll need:

- A clean jar, box, or container
- Small pieces of paper or colorful sticky notes
- Pens or markers

Instructions:

1. **Brainstorm:** Look back at the self-care menu above. Think about what activities from each section appeal to you the most. What do you *enjoy* doing? What makes you feel *good*?
2. **Write It Down:** On each small piece of paper, write down ONE self-care activity. Be specific! Instead of just 'Music,' write 'Listen to my favorite upbeat playlist' or 'Sing loudly in the shower.'

3. **Get Creative:** You can draw little pictures on the slips of paper, use different colored pens, or add glitter if you like! Make them fun and visually appealing.
4. **Fold and Fill:** Fold each piece of paper and place it into your jar.
5. **Use Your Jar:** When you're feeling stressed, bored, or just need a moment for yourself, close your eyes, pick a slip of paper from the jar, and do the activity! Don't overthink it, just pick one and go for it.

This makes self-care accessible and removes the pressure of deciding what to do. It's a fun, hands-on way to build healthy habits!

Remember, self-care is a powerful tool. By regularly checking in with yourself and engaging in activities that nourish you, you're building resilience and a stronger sense of well-being. Keep exploring, keep experimenting, and most importantly, be kind to yourself along the way!